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A FIELD GUIDE TO THE ISLAND

Living in Bali

Visas, land, banking, bikes —
and the life you actually came for.

SHAIDEN VALENTINE

“The life you want is usually closer — and simpler to reach — than you think.”

Living in Bali · First edition · 2026

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Prices are shown in Indonesian rupiah (Rp / IDR) with rough USD equivalents at about Rp 16,000 to the dollar. Exchange rates and rules move — treat every number as directional.

READ THIS FIRST

This is the map I wish someone had handed me — not legal, tax, or immigration advice.

Indonesia's visa, company, land, and tax rules change often, and they're applied differently from one office, notary, and regency to the next. Several things in here shifted in 2025 alone. Use this guide to understand the landscape and ask better questions — then verify every figure with a licensed visa agent, notary (notaris/PPAT), and tax consultant before you act on it.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Why I built a life here.

I'll say it plainly, because I've earned the right to: **I genuinely believe Bali is the best place to visit — or live — in the world.**

That's not a holiday-glow take. I've been to **over eighty countries**. I've seen most of the world, and I've seen it properly. And out of everywhere I've ever been, nowhere comes close to the **bang for your buck** Bali gives you — on lifestyle, on the people you meet, on quality of life, health, wellness, the food, the places you get to call home. It's the best place I've found, by a long shot, and I genuinely can't recommend it enough. I'd put my whole reputation on that, having gone and seen it all.

In my other book, **The Game of Life**, I wrote that you are largely the sum of your inputs — the people around you, your habits, your body, and the place you wake up in. Bali was the single biggest input I ever changed on purpose. Warm mornings, surf before work, a community of people building real things, a cost of living that buys back your time, and enough beauty to keep you grateful — it rewired what a normal day felt like.

The only catch is the start. When you first arrive, the visas, the phone, the bike, the lease — it can feel like a lot, mostly because no one lays it out for you in one place. But here's the truth: **it's really not that much once you can see it whole**. It's a handful of things, done once, in the right order — and that's exactly what this book is. Not an encyclopedia of red tape;

just the short list of what actually matters, so you can knock it out in your first few weeks and forget about it.

This is everything I'd tell a close friend who messaged me saying, "I think I want to move to Bali — where do I even start?" It's organized in the order you'll actually need it: land the plane, build your base, sort daily life, then go live the part you came for. Read it once to see the whole board. Then use it like a checklist when it's your turn.

It's the best place on earth, and getting set up here is simpler than it looks. This is everything you actually need to know — nothing more.

HOW TO USE THIS

**Read once. Then
work it.**

This is a practical book. It's built to be read in an afternoon — and then opened again every time you hit a wall.

The first pass, just read. You'll get the lay of the land: which visa fits you, how property actually works, why your phone might stop working in a month, and where you'll probably want to live. Don't try to action it all at once.

Then come back and use the **boxes**. Throughout you'll find three kinds:

KEY FACT

The thing most people get wrong, stated plainly.

WATCH OUT

A trap, scam, or rule that costs newcomers real money.

MY TAKE

What I'd actually do, personally — not just what's possible.

At the very end there's a **first-30-days checklist** and a one-page reference of the numbers that matter. Tear those out. And remember the disclaimer: this is a map, not advice — confirm the specifics with a professional before you sign anything.

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The map.

Four parts, in the order you'll need them.

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PART ONE

Land the Plane

Getting in, staying legally, and the
immigration moves that decide
everything else.

PART I — LAND THE PLANE

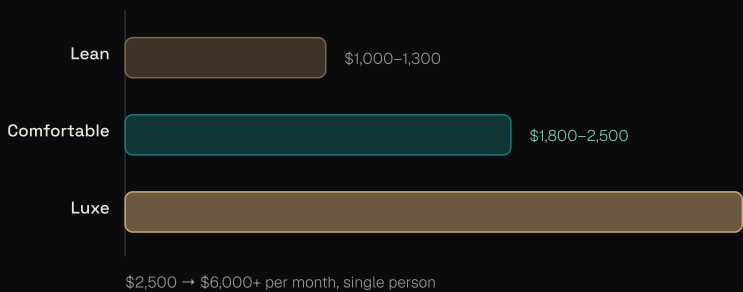
01

**Why Bali — and who
it's really for.**

Before the logistics, be honest about the why. Bali rewards people who come to build a life, and quietly punishes people who come to run from one.

What makes the island special isn't the postcard. It's the **combination**: a low cost of living that buys back your time, a dense community of founders, creatives, and athletes all leveling up at once, world-class surf and nature on your doorstep, and a culture of wellness and intentionality that's genuinely contagious. Stack those inputs and your default day gets better — which, over a year, changes who you become.

It's not flawless. The traffic is real. The bureaucracy is real. The "Bali belly," the rainy-season downpours, the occasional power cut, the friends who arrive and leave every few months — all real. The people who thrive here aren't chasing an endless holiday; they're using the island as a base to do focused work and live well. Come for that and Bali is hard to beat.



WHAT A MONTH ACTUALLY COSTS

MY TAKE

Treat your first stint as a test, not a tattoo. Come for 60–90 days on a tourist visa, live like you actually live (work hours and all), and only then commit to a KITAS, a lease, or a company. The island sells itself on a two-week trip; you want to know how it feels on a normal Tuesday.

The rest of Part I is about the single thing that makes everything else legal and calm: getting your visa right.

PART I — LAND THE PLANE

02

Visas decoded: tourist to KITAS.

Indonesia's visas look like alphabet soup — B1, C1, E28A, E33G — but they sort into two buckets: **short stays** (tourist) and **limited-stay permits** (KITAS) that let you actually live here.

Short stays — for testing the water

Visa on Arrival (VoA / eVoA)

The default for most Western passports. **Rp 500,000 (~\$35)** for 30 days, extendable **once** for another 30 — so **60 days maximum**. Buy the eVoA online before you fly at the official portal, evisa.imigrasi.go.id. Beware copycat scam sites; only trust the [.imigrasi.go.id](https://imigrasi.go.id) domain.

WATCH OUT

Since around mid-2025, extending a VoA is a **hybrid process**: you start online, then show up **in person** at the local immigration office for fingerprints, a photo, and a short interview. The old "agent handles everything, you never appear" extension is gone. Budget half a day.

B211A / C1 visit visa

The serious tester. **60 days** to start, single entry, with **two 60-day extensions** — up to **180 consecutive days** without leaving. Roughly **Rp 1.9M (~\$120)** via an agent, plus extension fees. It does **not** permit working for or earning from Indonesian sources.

Visa exemption (visa-free)

Free, 30 days, **non-extendable** — and mostly for ASEAN nationals (plus Brazil and Turkey since July 2025). Most US/UK/EU/Australian passports are **not** exempt and should use the paid eVoA.

The KITAS family — for living here

A KITAS (Kartu Izin Tinggal Terbatas) is a limited-stay permit. This is the line between visiting and living. The main ones:

KITAS	FOR	VALIDITY
E28A — Investor	Owners/directors of a PT PMA company	1–2 years
E23 — Working	Employees sponsored by a company	~1 year
E33G — Remote worker	Nomads employed abroad	1 year
E33F — Retirement	Retirees (55/60+)	1 year, renewable
E33 — Second home	Self-funded, no sponsor	5–10 years
KITAP	Permanent stay (after years on a KITAS)	5 years

The next chapter walks you through which of these is actually you, with the real numbers and trade-offs. For now, just hold

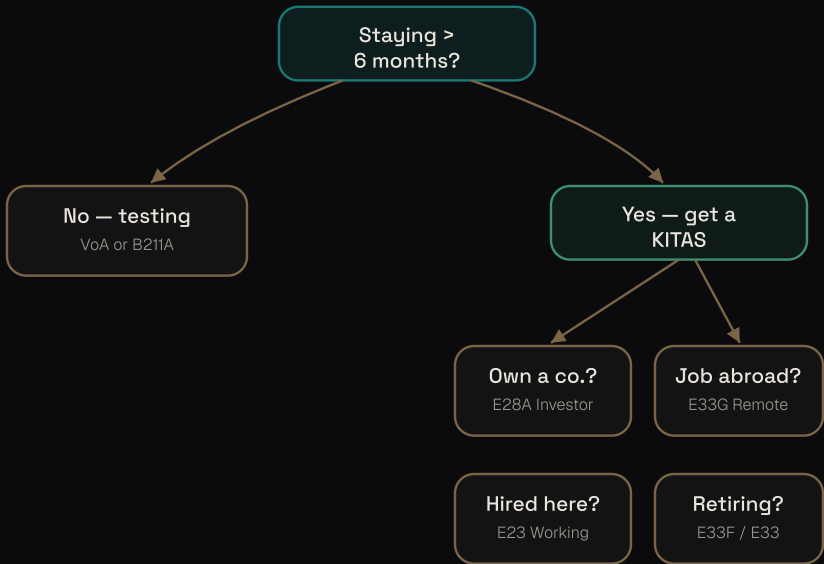
the shape: tourist visas to test, a KITAS to live, KITAP to stay
for good.

PART I — LAND THE PLANE

03

**Which visa is actually
you.**

Pick by how you make money and how long you're staying.
Here's the honest decision tree.



HOW TO CHOOSE YOUR VISA

Investor KITAS (E28A) — the founder’s route

Sponsored by **your own** PT PMA company (you sit as director or commissioner). Typically **2 years**, multiple re-entry, and crucially **no separate work permit (RPTKA) needed** for a board role. Agent-inclusive cost is often cited around **\$1,200** for the 2-year version — but it only exists if you've set up the company (Chapter 7). This is the path most location-independent founders here end up on.

Remote Worker KITAS (E33G) — the nomad visa

For people employed or contracting **for a company registered outside Indonesia**. Requirements: prove ~\$60,000/year income, about \$2,000 in savings held over the prior 3 months, and remote work with no Indonesian clients. **1 year**, renewable; you must enter within 90 days of issue. All-in cost around **Rp 13M (~\$800–900)**. If you're a salaried remote employee, this is usually your cleanest option.

Working KITAS (E23) — sponsored by an employer

Tied to an Indonesian company that sponsors you. Needs an approved **RPTKA** (foreign-worker plan) and a **DKP-TKA levy of \$100/month**, usually pre-paid for the visa's duration. ~1 year. All-in commonly **\$2,500–4,000**.

Retirement (E33F) & Second Home (E33)

Retirement historically started at age **55**, though 2026 sources suggest the bar is moving toward **60+** for many nationalities — verify. Expect to show pension/income (figures cited range \$1,500–3,000/month) and a long-term lease. After 5 straight years you can reach **KITAP**. The **Second Home** visa (5 or 10 years, no sponsor) trades a proof-of-funds requirement for length and freedom.

What you can and can't actually do

This is where people get into trouble — "working" in Indonesia has a specific legal meaning, and the wrong visa for your

income is the fastest way onto immigration's radar. The simple rule: **your visa has to match how you make your money.**

VISA	YOU CAN	YOU CAN'T
Tourist (VoA / B211A)	Holiday, scout, take meetings	Work, or earn any income — foreign or local
E33G Remote	Work remotely for a foreign employer/clients	Take Indonesian clients, sell into Indonesia, or be self-employed locally
E28A Investor	Direct & oversee your own PT PMA, draw from it	Take a hands-on "employee" job at another company without a work permit
E23 Working	Work the specific role your sponsor hired you for	Work for anyone other than the sponsor on your RPTKA

WATCH OUT — THE GREY ZONE

The big one people miss: a **tourist visa permits zero income**, even remote work for a company back home, technically. In practice many nomads test the water this way, but it's exactly what the 2025 crackdown targets. The moment Bali is your base and you're earning, get onto an **E33G** (foreign income) or an **E28A** via your own company. And the E33G line that catches people: **no Indonesian clients and no selling to the Indonesian market** — the income must originate abroad.

MY TAKE

Don't agonize over the "perfect" visa from your couch. Land on a tourist visa, talk to two reputable agents in person, and let your **actual** situation — company or no company, income source, timeline — pick the lane. The right answer is usually obvious once a good agent hears your specifics.

PART I — LAND THE PLANE

04

Limits, overstays & the crackdown.

Indonesia got serious about enforcement in 2024–2025. The era of casually "working on a tourist visa" and stringing together endless visa runs is over. Play it straight — it's cheaper and far less stressful.

The hard limits

- **VoA:** 60 days maximum (30 + one extension), then you leave.
- **B211A / C1:** up to 180 consecutive days (60 + two extensions), then you leave.
- Past those, you need a KITAS — there's no more stacking tourist time.

WATCH OUT — OVERSTAY

Overstaying is **Rp 1,000,000 per day**, payable in cash at the airport before you board. Stay 32 days on a 30-day permit and you'll hand over Rp 2,000,000. Overstay beyond ~60 days and you're looking at **deportation and a blacklist** — a re-entry ban that runs anywhere from 1 to 6 years.

The 2025 enforcement reality

Immigration enforcement actions jumped sharply year-on-year, and sweeps like **Operation Wirawaspada** (December 2025) detained hundreds of foreigners in a matter of weeks — the top violations being **misusing a residence permit** (e.g. working on the wrong visa) and **overstaying**. Digital nomads

quietly working without the proper permit are an explicit target now.

The takeaway isn't fear — it's simple: match your visa to what you're actually doing. If you earn money while living here, get on the right KITAS. The cost of doing it properly is a rounding error next to a deportation and a multi-year ban from the place you want to live.

The cheapest visa is the correct one. Everything else has a hidden bill.

PART I — LAND THE PLANE

05

The SKTT & registering your address.

Get a KITAS and you'll immediately hear a new acronym: SKTT. It's the step everyone forgets, and it quietly unlocks the rest of your admin life.

An **SKTT** (**Surat Keterangan Tempat Tinggal**) is a **temporary residence certificate** for foreigners holding a KITAS — effectively your official "I live at this address in Indonesia" registration. The important twist: it's issued not by Immigration but by the regional **Dukcapil / Disdukcapil** (the population & civil registration office).

KEY FACT

You're generally expected to register for the SKTT **within 14 days** of your KITAS being issued. It's officially **free**, and it's often required downstream — for banking, your driving licence, and other civil paperwork. Don't skip it.

What you'll typically bring

- Your KITAS and passport (plus copies)
- A police report / registration letter (STM/SKLD), where required
- An application letter and passport photos (2×3 cm)
- Proof of address — your lease

Requirements vary by regency, so confirm with your local office or let your visa agent bundle it with the KITAS. With your KITAS and SKTT in hand, you're a registered resident — and

Part II, building your financial and physical base, becomes possible.

PART TWO

Build the Base

Money, company, and a place to stand
— the foundations that make Bali a
home, not a holiday.

PART II — BUILD THE BASE

06

Opening a bank account.

Day-to-day Bali runs on a local account, a local number, and QRIS. My recommendation, after trying the alternatives: [open with BCA](#).

Why BCA

- **The biggest ATM and branch network** on the island — you'll find one in almost every town.
- **The best app.** The newer [myBCA](#) app is English-friendly, with biometric login, and pulls your savings, cards, QRIS, and Flazz into one place.
- **Flazz** — BCA's tap card for tolls, parking, and convenience stores, toppable inside the app.
- **QRIS** — Indonesia's universal scan-to-pay standard. In Bali you'll pay for warungs, cafés, and markets straight from the app. This is how money actually moves here.
- **BCA Dollar & Poket Valas** — hold USD/SGD and (since 2025) ~16 currencies in foreign-currency pockets, useful if your income lands from abroad.

KEY FACT

The single biggest gatekeeper is a **KITAS**. With one, opening a BCA account is straightforward (30 min–2 hours). As a tourist with no KITAS, you'll usually be turned away unless you go through an agent with pre-arranged bank relationships. Don't believe every "tourists can open accounts" blog — confirm with the specific branch.

What to bring

- Your **KITAS** (ideally 6+ months validity)
- **Passport** — original plus copies of photo and visa pages
- A **local phone number** — mandatory for OTP/mobile banking, so buy your SIM **first** (Chapter 11)
- **Proof of address** (your lease) and, often, your **NPWP** tax number

The standard **Tahapan** account opens with around **Rp 500,000** and costs a token **Rp 15,000–25,000/month** in admin. If an agent quotes a Rp 10–20M minimum, they're steering you to a premium tier — the basic Tahapan is far cheaper.

MY TAKE

BCA is my daily driver for exactly one reason: friction. The app just works, the QR is everywhere, and you're never far from an ATM. I keep a **Wise** account for cheap international transfers in, then move rupiah to BCA for spending. Mandiri and BNI are fine backups; Jenius/BTPN is a slick digital option but still wants a KITAS.

PART II — BUILD THE BASE

07

The PT PMA: your company.

If you're going to run a business here, own a villa properly, or sponsor your own Investor KITAS, the vehicle is a **PT PMA** — a foreign-owned Indonesian limited company. It's the legal key that unlocks most of "living here for real."

PT PMA stands for **Perseroan Terbatas Penanaman Modal Asing** — a limited-liability company with foreign ownership. It can hold property rights (HGB, see Chapter 8), run a legitimate business, and sponsor you onto the E28A Investor KITAS with no separate work permit.

The numbers (as of late 2025)

WATCH OUT — THIS CHANGED

Under **BKPM/Investment Regulation No. 5/2025** (effective ~October 2025), the figures most people quote are out of date.

The two numbers to separate:

- **Investment plan: > Rp 10 billion** (~\$625–650k) per business classification per location — a **commitment**, excluding land & buildings.
 - **Paid-up capital: Rp 2.5 billion** (~\$155k) actually deposited at incorporation — **reduced** from the old Rp 10B many guides still cite.
-
- Minimum **2 shareholders**.
 - Your activities are defined by **KBLI codes** — each has its own foreign-ownership limits and capital rules, so picking

the right ones is critical.

- Registration runs through the **OSS** system under BKPM, with quarterly **LKPM** investment reports required afterward.

Cost & timeline

Professional setup (notary, registration, OSS licensing) typically runs **\$3,000–7,000** on top of the capital itself, with annual accounting and tax compliance after. Expect **2–4 months** to a fully operational, property-capable company. Given the KBLI, OSS, and capital-verification complexity, a good agent or notary isn't optional — it's the whole game.

MY TAKE

A PT PMA is powerful but it's a real commitment with ongoing costs and filings. Don't form one just to "be set up." Form one when you have a genuine business or a property you intend to hold for the long term — then it pays for itself through the Investor KITAS and legitimate ownership.

PART II — BUILD THE BASE

08

**Land & property:
what you can really
own.**

The first rule, and the one that saves people from disaster: **foreigners cannot own freehold land in Indonesia.**

Freehold (**Hak Milik**) is reserved for Indonesian citizens. Full stop. Everything legal flows from three other routes.

Hak Milik — Freehold

Indonesians only. Foreigners: never directly.

Leasehold (Hak Sewa)

25–30 yrs, prepaid. Cheapest, simplest, most common.

Hak Pakai — Right to Use

In your name, but needs a KITAS/KITAP. Up to 80 yrs.

HGB — Right to Build (via PT PMA)

Company-held. For villas & rental businesses. Up to 80 yrs.

THE FOUR WAYS LAND IS HELD — AND WHICH ARE OPEN TO YOU

Leasehold (Hak Sewa) — the common route

A prepaid lease, usually **25–30 years**. No company, no residency permit needed. Lowest entry cost (buyer fees of just ~**2–4%**, and **no 5% acquisition tax**), and leasehold villas typically run **30–50% cheaper** than equivalent freehold. This is how most expats hold a home here.

Hak Pakai — in your own name

If you hold a KITAS/KITAP, you can own a **Right to Use** property directly — including strata-title apartments — for an initial 30

years, extendable up to roughly 80. It's tied to your residency status.

HGB via a PT PMA — for building & business

A **Right to Build** (Hak Guna Bangunan) runs **30 + 20 + 30 years** — up to about **80 years**, and the term doesn't reset on sale. Only Indonesian citizens or entities can hold it, so as a foreigner you hold it through your **PT PMA**. This is the route for villas you'll rent out or develop.

WATCH OUT — NOMINEES & ZONING

Putting freehold land in a local "friend's" or paid nominee's name while you're the real owner is **illegal and unenforceable** — you have no real ownership, and Bali is actively cracking down on exactly this. Equally dangerous: building in a **green zone (zona hijau)**. In 2024–2025 authorities demolished dozens of illegal cliffside villas at Bingin and elsewhere. Zoning is not a formality here.

PART II — BUILD THE BASE

09

**Leasing or buying
without getting
burned.**

Bali property is full of beautiful deals and quiet landmines. The difference between the two is almost always **due diligence** — done by a licensed notary, before money moves.

Always verify, before you sign

- ☐ The landowner's **original Hak Milik certificate** and identity (checked at the land office, BPN)
- ☐ **Zoning** (RTRW spatial plan) permits your intended use — especially rentals; avoid green zones
- ☐ A valid **PBG** building approval (this replaced the old "IMB" in 2021) and an **SLF** fitness certificate for completed builds
- ☐ For a lease: the **remaining term and the extension clause** — at what price can you renew?
- ☐ A proper **notarized deed** — never just a private, handwritten agreement

KEY FACT

Hire a **notaris/PPAT** (licensed land-deed official). Their fee runs ~1–2.5% of the transaction, and full due diligence ~\$500–2,000. It is the cheapest insurance you will ever buy in Indonesia.

The transaction taxes

TAX	RATE	WHO PAYS
BPHTB (acquisition)	5%	Buyer — leasehold exempt
PPh (seller's income)	2.5%	Seller
VAT (new builds)	~11–12%	Buyer
PBB (annual)	0.1–0.5%	Owner

Ballpark prices (2025–2026)

Land leases run roughly **\$180–1,800 per are (100 m²) per year** depending on location. Villa sale prices, very roughly: **Canggu** \$300k–1M+, **Uluwatu** \$650k+ for luxury, **Ubud** \$200–600k, with **Seseh/Cemagi** materially cheaper than Seminyak/Canggu for comparable space. These move fast — treat them as directional.

MY TAKE

For your first year, **lease, don't buy**. Rent annually (far cheaper per month than monthly deals), learn the micro-areas, and only commit capital once you know exactly which street you want to wake up on. Buying in Bali is a great move made too early by a lot of people.

PART II — BUILD THE BASE

10

Tax, simply.

Tax is where confident-sounding internet advice does the most damage. Here's the honest version — then go get individualized advice, because your home country matters too.

KEY FACT — THE 183-DAY RULE

Spend more than **183 days** in Indonesia within any 12 months (the days don't have to be consecutive) and you're generally an Indonesian **tax resident**, taxable on your **worldwide income**.
KITAS holders are typically treated as residents from arrival.

How residency actually works

Tax residency is the concept everything hangs on, so it's worth getting right:

- **You can be a resident of two places — or neither.**

Crossing 183 days makes you an Indonesian tax resident, but it doesn't automatically end residency back home.

Many countries (the US taxes on citizenship; others use their own day-count or "centre of life" tests) will still consider you resident until you properly cut ties. You have to actively manage your **home-country** exit, not just your Indonesian entry.

- **Double-tax treaties (DTAs) are the safety net.** Indonesia has treaties with many countries that decide who taxes what and let you credit tax paid in one against the other, so the same income isn't taxed twice. Which treaty applies,

and the "tie-breaker" rules, depend entirely on your nationality — this is the part to take to a professional.

- **Residency is about presence, not paperwork.** It's triggered by the days you're physically here, not by which visa you hold. You can be on a tourist visa and still trip the 183-day line in the eyes of the tax office.
- **NPWP is how you formalize it.** Once resident, you register for an NPWP (tax number) and file annually. Banks and the bigger admin tasks often ask for it anyway.

For a resident, the rates that apply:

- **NPWP** — your tax number, needed to file (and often requested by banks).
- **Personal income tax** — progressive, **5% to 35%**. Non-residents pay a flat 20% on Indonesian-source income.
- **Corporate tax (PT PMA)** — **22%** on net profit. Note: a PT PMA can't use the 0.5% small-business facility a local PT might.
- **VAT** — generally ~11%, drifting toward 12%.

WATCH OUT — THE "0% NOMAD TAX" MYTH

You'll see agencies market a "0% tax on foreign income" for nomads. Indonesia's law **does** have a narrow territorial incentive (qualifying skilled foreigners, 0% on foreign-source income for up to 4 years) — but it's **narrow**, tied to specialist/knowledge-transfer roles, and **does not automatically apply** to a typical E33G remote worker. The default rule keys on physical presence, not where income was "earned." Don't plan around the marketing.

Bottom line: once you cross 183 days, get a real Indonesian tax consultant **and** understand your home country's rules and any double-tax treaty. This is the one area where a few hundred dollars of advice saves you from five-figure mistakes.

PART THREE

Daily Life

Phones, bikes, licences, insurance, a
roof — the unglamorous machinery
that makes the island feel like home.

PART III — DAILY LIFE

11

**Phone, SIM & your
local number.**

A local number isn't optional. Landlords, scooter rentals, drivers, restaurants, your bank — everything in Bali runs on **WhatsApp**, tied to an Indonesian number. Sort this in your first 48 hours.

Which provider

- **Telkomsel** — the best, most reliable coverage island-wide, including the Bukit and the north. Premium price. Its **by.U** sub-brand is eSIM-friendly and popular with nomads.
- **Indosat (IM3)** — great value, strong in the south (Canggu, Ubud, Denpasar).
- **XL** — affordable, decent southern coverage. **Smartfren** — cheapest, weakest; tourist hubs only.

Data is cheap: typical packages run **Rp 100,000–200,000** (~\$6–13) for 30–80 GB a month. Buy from a proper store in Canggu, Seminyak, Ubud, or Denpasar rather than an airport kiosk — cheaper, with more options. By law your SIM is **registered to your passport**; the shop does it for you.

MY TAKE

Go **Telkomsel** if you'll spend time on the Bukit or travel the island — the coverage difference is real when you're up a cliff in Uluwatu or out in Sidemen. Set up WhatsApp the moment the SIM is active; it's the actual operating system of life here. **But read the next chapter before you put a local SIM in your phone.**

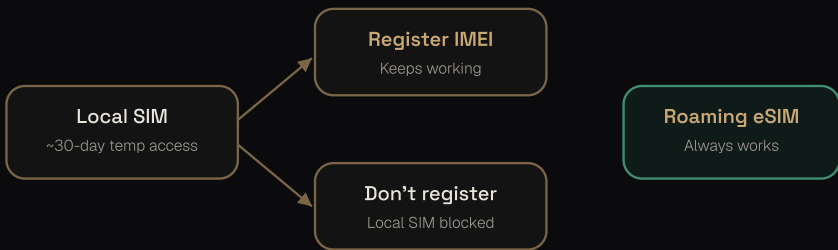
PART III — DAILY LIFE

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The IMEI trap.

Let me make this simple, because it confuses everyone. **Indonesia blocks foreign phones from its local mobile networks unless you register the phone with customs.** Think of it as your **phone** needing its own little visa — separate from yours.

Every phone has an **IMEI** — a serial number baked into the hardware. When you buy a cheap local SIM (Telkomsel, etc.) and put it in a phone you brought from abroad, it works at first — but after about **30 days the local network cuts that phone off**, because its IMEI was never registered. Your phone isn't broken; Wi-Fi and your home SIM still work. You just lose the cheap local data until you register. That's the whole "trap" — and it's easy to avoid.



THE IMEI DECISION, IN ONE PICTURE

THE SIMPLE VERSION — PICK ONE

You only really have two choices:

- **Easiest — use a roaming eSIM** (Airalo, Holafly). It runs through international carriers, so IMEI rules don't touch it. Works the second you land, never gets blocked, zero registration. Perfect for a first visit or your first few weeks.
- **Cheapest long-term — register the phone, then buy a local SIM.** Register your phone's IMEI with customs **at the airport when you arrive** (free, takes minutes), then a Telkomsel SIM works forever. This is the move once you're staying.

(Your normal **home SIM on roaming** always works too — it's only the cheap **local** SIM that needs the phone registered.)

How to register permanently

1. **At the airport on arrival (best).** Since 1 Oct 2025 you declare via the new "All Indonesia" arrival app/site — keep the **QR code**. The IMEI desk in Denpasar (DPS) sits after baggage claim, before the exit. Bring passport, boarding pass, the phone, and the QR.
2. **At a Bea Cukai (customs) office** later, if you miss the airport (a window of up to ~60 days is cited — verify).
3. **Avoid the "grey" registration services.** They can be reversed, are sometimes scams, and aren't worth the risk for a long-term move.

WATCH OUT — THE DUTY MATH

Duty-free exemption is **\$500 per person** (up to 2 devices).

Under that, registration is free. Over it, you pay **40% import tax on the amount above \$500** (KITAS/NPWP holders may get ~30% — confirm). A \$900 phone → ~\$160 in duty. So think twice before flying in with a brand-new \$1,200 flagship.

MY TAKE

Honestly, just register at the **airport when you land** — it takes a few minutes and then you never think about it again. Only catch it early and it's a non-issue. The only people who get caught out are the ones who pop in a local SIM, forget, and wonder why it dies a month later.

PART III — DAILY LIFE

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Bikes & cars.

Bali moves on two wheels. A scooter is the single biggest upgrade to your daily freedom here — and the thing to be most careful with. But before you even touch a bike, download two apps.

KEY FACT — GET THESE ON DAY ONE

Download **Grab** and **Gojek** the moment you land. They do the same thing — on-demand **rides** (car or motorbike), **food delivery**, and couriering almost anything across the island — and between them they run daily life here. Grab is the one I'd call most essential, but get both; coverage and prices differ by area, so you'll want to compare. On a day you don't feel like riding, a GoRide bike taxi appears in minutes for a couple of dollars.

Rent first

Almost everyone rents for the first months. Monthly rates: a standard scooter (Scoopy, Vario) runs **Rp 700k–1.5M (~\$45–93)**; a bigger NMAX/PCX **Rp 1.8–3.5M**; cars roughly **Rp 3.5–6M**. Rentals usually include two helmets, a phone holder, and delivery.

Buying a scooter

Worth it past ~6–12 months. New, in Denpasar: a Honda **Scoopy ~Rp 20.5–23.7M**, **Vario 125 ~Rp 24–26.5M**, PCX/NMAX higher. Used Scoopys go **Rp 12–15M**. Foreigners get quoted inflated prices — compare on OLX/Facebook groups or buy through a local.

The three documents

- **STNK** — the annual registration certificate. Carry it always.
- **BPKB** — the ownership logbook (the "title"). Keep it safe at home, never on the bike.
- **Plat nomor** — the licence plate.

KEY FACT — HOW TO REGISTER IT PROPERLY

As a foreigner you can register a bike or car two legal ways:

- **In your PT PMA** — the company owns the vehicle (clean, and what most long-term residents with a company do).
- **In your own name** — if you hold a **KITAS** and an **SKTT** (your residence certificate from Chapter 5), you can register it personally, usually alongside a KTP/NPWP.

WATCH OUT — THE SELLER'S-NAME SHORTCUT

Without a KITAS/SKTT or a PT PMA, many foreigners just leave the bike **in the seller's name** and skip the transfer (*balik nama*). It avoids paperwork but means you don't legally own it — and it resells for 20–30% less. Annual tax (*pajak*) on a motorbike runs ~Rp 400–600k via SAMSAT; pay it on time to avoid penalties.

Cars work the same way — same STNK/BPKB/plat system, much higher tax. Used Avanza/Xenia-class cars commonly run ~Rp 100–160M.

PART III — DAILY LIFE

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SIM A & SIM C: licences & the road.

Riding here without the right licence is the most common — and most expensive — mistake newcomers make. Not because of the fines, but because a crash without a valid licence usually **voids your insurance**.

KEY FACT — TWO LICENCES

SIM C = motorbike/scooter. **SIM A** = car (up to 3,500 kg). They're **separate** — you need both if you drive both. Each is valid 5 years.

As a tourist: get an IDP

On a tourist visa you can legally drive on your **home licence plus an International Driving Permit (IDP)**. Get it in your home country **before** you arrive — it's cheap and it's your best protection at checkpoints. Crucially, the IDP must list the **motorcycle class**; a car-only IDP doesn't cover a scooter. Carry both the IDP and your original licence.

As a resident: the local SIM

With a KITAS you can get a local Indonesian licence. In Bali that's at **Polresta Denpasar** (Jl. Gunung Sanghyang No. 110). Cost is **Rp 200,000 per licence** — Rp 400,000 for both A and C — plus a health check. There's a theory and a practical test; with a valid IDP and home licence you may be exempt (applied inconsistently — verify). It's often done in a single ~2–3 hour visit.

WATCH OUT — CHECKPOINTS

Police checkpoints are common on tourist routes and increasingly target foreigners. They check your **STNK, licence, IDP, and helmet**. An official ticket (**tilang resmi**) runs Rp 300k–1M; officers often offer to "settle" for Rp 200–500k cash. Saying "**Saya minta tilang resmi**" ("I request an official ticket") usually ends a shakedown, since the paper trail exposes them. Always wear the helmet — it's the law and it's your head.

PART III — DAILY LIFE

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Insurance & staying healthy.

Bali is wonderful right up until something goes wrong — a scooter spill, a stubborn infection, a real emergency. Good insurance is the difference between an inconvenience and a catastrophe.

Health insurance

- **International plans** (best for most): Cigna Global, Allianz Care, IMG, William Russell, April International — comprehensive, often with direct billing at Bali's good hospitals. Budget roughly **\$150–350/month**.
- **Nomads:** **SafetyWing** Nomad Insurance (~\$56/month, buy it even while already here) for lighter cover; their Global Medical for more.
- **BPJS Kesehatan** — the national scheme, semi-mandatory for KITAS holders at **~Rp 150,000/month**. Treat it as a legal-compliance baseline (designated public hospital, long waits), not your primary cover.

WATCH OUT

Most policies **exclude motorbike accidents if you were helmetless or unlicensed** — the single most common claim in Bali. Make sure your plan explicitly covers scooter riding **and** that you hold a valid licence/IDP, or you're effectively uninsured on the road.

Where to get treated

- **BIMC** (Kuta & Nusa Dua) — expat favorite, 24h ER, direct billing with most insurers.
- **Siloam** — large JCI-accredited private network.
- **Kasih Ibu** — respected private group, several locations.
- **Bali International Hospital** (Sanur, opened 2025) — built for international patients.
- **RSUP Ngoerah** (formerly Sanglah) — the main public hospital; critical cases get referred here.

KEY FACT — MEDEVAC MATTERS

The most serious cases (major trauma, cardiac, neuro) are routinely **evacuated to Singapore**. That flight costs **\$25,000–100,000+** out of pocket. Make sure your policy **explicitly** includes **emergency medical evacuation and repatriation** with a high limit. This is the line item that justifies the whole premium.

PART III — DAILY LIFE

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**Leases & finding
somewhere to live.**

Where you live is the input that colors every day. Here's how renting actually works — and how to not overpay or get stuck.

The price ladder

The golden rule: **yearly contracts are dramatically cheaper per month** than monthly deals. A villa you'd pay Rp 25M/month for on Airbnb might be Rp 12–15M/month on a 12-month lease. Monthly flexibility is a luxury you pay heavily for.

- **Budget:** a room or simple studio, ~\$400–700/month.
- **Comfortable:** a 1-bed villa with a pool, ~Rp 12–25M (\$750–1,560).
- **Premium:** design villas, ocean views, 2+ beds — Rp 30–45M+ and up.

How to find it

- **Facebook groups** (e.g. "Bali Housing / Villas for Rent") and **WhatsApp** are where real long-term deals live.
- Local **agents** for villas — useful, but always negotiate; first prices are rarely final.
- Stay somewhere short-term first and **scooter around the actual streets** before signing a year.

WATCH OUT — BEFORE YOU SIGN

Check the **water** (is it well water? clean? pressure?), **internet speed** (test it — fibre varies wildly even on the Bukit), **noise** (nearby construction, roosters, a beach club, the mosque), and exactly **what's included** (pool/garden maintenance, staff, electricity — power can be a real monthly cost with AC). Get the full term and deposit terms in writing.

MY TAKE

Don't sign a 12-month lease in your first week. Take a 1-month place, feel out two or three areas in real life, then commit. The yearly discount is huge — but only worth it once you're sure of the street, not just the island.

PART FOUR

Live It

The part you actually came for — but
first, the spirit to come in with.

BEFORE YOU DIVE IN

Respect the island.

Before the surf, the gyms, and the dinners, one thing matters more than all of it: **honour the place you've come to**. Bali is not a backdrop for your highlight reel. It's a living, deeply spiritual culture — and that culture is the entire reason the island feels the way it does.

The Balinese live by a philosophy called **Tri Hita Karana** — harmony between people, nature, and the divine. You feel it everywhere: the little palm-leaf offerings (**canang sari**) laid out on doorsteps and dashboards each morning, the temples on every corner, the processions that will stop your scooter in its tracks. None of it is performance. It's a genuine, daily devotion to keeping life in balance, and you're a guest inside it.

And the people. In all my eighty-plus countries, I have never met anyone like the Balinese — among the **most patient, gentle, and genuinely peaceful people on earth**. They will meet you with a warmth most of the world has forgotten. The only right response is to give it back: treat them well, treat their home well, and move through the island with humility rather than entitlement.

If you're going to walk all over the place and its people, why did you come here at all?

How to actually respect it

- **Temples:** wear a sarong and sash, dress modestly, never climb on shrines or sacred statues, and don't step over or

on offerings on the ground.

- **The land:** don't litter — ever. Take your trash, refuse single-use plastic where you can, respect the reefs and the rice paddies you're lucky to live among.
- **The people:** learn a few words — **terima kasih** (thank you), **om swastiastu** (a respectful greeting). Be patient, smile, and never raise your voice. Anger and impatience are deeply disrespectful here.
- **Pay fairly** and tip well. The cost of living that buys back your time is built on local wages.

WATCH OUT — KEEP IT CLEAN & SOBER

This is a peaceful place. Don't show up to it drunk, loud, or high. Beyond the disrespect, **Indonesia has some of the harshest drug laws on earth** — possession lands foreigners in prison, and trafficking can carry the death penalty. It is not worth it, full stop. Leave that version of yourself at the airport.

Come to go deep, not numb

Here's my honest plea: Bali is a place to **calm your nervous system and go inward**, not to chase the next hit of dopamine. A wave of hedonistic beach clubs has overtaken parts of the island — the endless party, the bottomless brunch, the noise. I'd skip almost all of it. It's the opposite of what makes this

place sacred, and you can find it anywhere in the world. You came to Bali; let Bali actually reach you.

Two experiences I'd send anyone to, to feel the real island:

GO DO THESE

- **The water ceremony (melukat) at Beji Griya Waterfall.** A traditional Balinese purification — a priest guides you through prayer and blessing beneath the falls. It is genuinely moving, and it resets something in you that a beach club never could.
- **The Bali Silent Retreat** (near Mount Batukaru). Phones away, voices down, real silence, simple food, and your own thoughts. A few days here will do more for your nervous system than a month of anything else on the island.

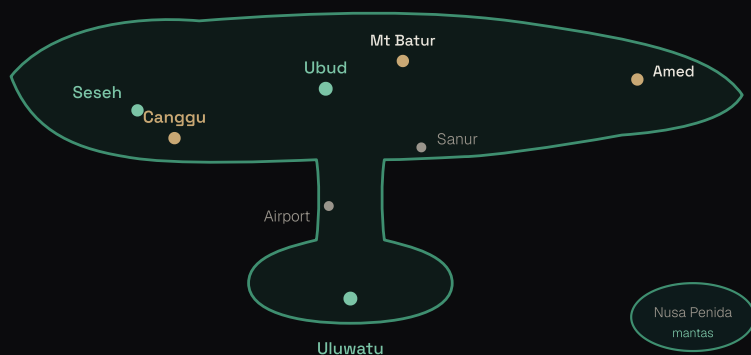
Do those, move through the rest with respect, and Bali gives you back something far deeper than a tan. That's the whole point.

PART IV — LIVE IT

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Where to live.

Bali isn't one place — it's a handful of very different worlds 30–90 minutes apart. There are loads of amazing spots on the island, but realistically **three areas** hold the best restaurants and the best expat scenes, and they're where almost everyone ends up living: **Seseh/Canggu**, **Uluwatu**, and **Ubud**. Here's the honest read on each.



THE ISLAND AT A GLANCE — GREEN DOTS ARE MY PICKS

Seseh — my pick for community & long-term living

The quiet coastal belt **just north of Canggu**, and for me the best place on the island to actually **live**. It has the strongest sense of community and the best feel for the long term: **beautiful black-sand beaches, rice terraces, open roads, and no traffic**. You get everything Canggu offers a short ride away, without any of the chaos. Property is meaningfully

cheaper here too, and the new **Omni** wellness club anchors the area. If I'm sending a friend who wants to put down roots, I send them to Seseh.

Canggu — the hub

The busy heart of expat Bali, just south of Seseh. There are far **more restaurants**, more going on, and more nightlife — a lot of people prefer it for exactly that energy. The trade-off is real: **more traffic and more chaos**. It's the hub, and there are more nightclubs here than anywhere. Great to be near; busier to live in full-time. (For housing detail, Seseh/Canggu are usually grouped together — most people split the difference.)

Uluwatu & the Bukit — surf & the best beaches

The cliff-and-surf south: drier, more design-led, and **the most surf-oriented** of the three. The beaches down here are the **most beautiful on the island — turquoise water** you won't quite believe — and the expat scene is genuinely excellent. **Bingin** is the bohemian surf village, **Padang Padang** livelier, **Pecatu/Ungasan** more spread-out and high-end. Car-dependent and spread out, but if you want world-class waves and the prettiest water, this is it.

Ubud — jungle & wellness

Inland, cooler, greener, no beach — the creative and wellness heart, and the third great option. Live in **South Ubud** (Penestanan, Nyuh Kuning, Pengosekan) to dodge the central

traffic. Best value of the lot, and unbeatable if you want a yoga-and-jungle reset as your baseline rather than surf.

AREA	BEST FOR	TRADE-OFF
Seseh	Community, long-term, calm	Newer, fewer cafés
Canggu	Restaurants, nightlife, hub	Traffic & chaos
Uluwatu	Surf, best beaches, scene	Spread out, car-needed
Ubud	Wellness, nature, value	No beach, traffic

WHERE IT GETS SOCIAL

My go-to nights out:

- **Mana** in Uluwatu on **Friday nights** — very social.
- **Black Sand** in Canggu on **Friday nights** — the other great Friday.
- **Udara** in Seseh on a **Sunday morning** — they run a Sunday-morning festival that's one of my favourite things on the island.
- **Nirvana** in Canggu is amazing, and **Savaya** in Uluwatu for the view if you want one big one.

MY TAKE

The cleanest version of why I love it here: **Seseh** for community and the long game, **Canggu** for restaurants and nights out, **Uluwatu** for surf and the prettiest water, **Ubud** for the wellness reset. Sample all of them on short stays before you sign a year anywhere.

PART IV — LIVE IT

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Gyms & training.

Bali has quietly become a genuinely serious place to train — world-class gyms, real recovery culture, and a community that actually shows up. Here are the ones worth knowing, by where you'll be living.

Seseh & Canggu — Omni, Nirvana, Reload

This is where the strongest cluster is, and the three I rotate between:

- **Omni** (Seseh/Munggu) — opened 2025 and the most premium gym on the island: a full wellness club with a 20m recovery pool, cold plunge, ice bath, sauna, juice bar, restaurant, co-working, Muay Thai. Around **Rp 4M / ~\$253 a month**. The all-in-one if you want training, recovery, work, and social in one place.
- **Nirvana** (Canggu) — a favourite of mine and a brilliant community gym: great classes, ice bath, breathwork, the lot. Doubles as recovery.
- **Reload** (Canggu) — excellent, focused strength training. My pick when I just want to lift.

Uluwatu — Bambu

On **Jl. Pantai Bingin**: a Tulum-inspired, serious-strength gym — Rogue, Eleiko, Concept2, CrossFit, weightlifting, real coaching, on-site canteen. Unlimited monthly is about **Rp 2.1M / ~\$130**. The one if you live on the Bukit and prioritise lifting and a tight crew.

GYM	AREA	BEST FOR
Omni	Seseh	Luxe all-in-one + recovery (~\$253)
Nirvana	Canggu	Classes, ice bath, community
Reload	Canggu	Focused strength
Bambu	Uluwatu	Strength / CrossFit (~\$130)

MY TAKE

Train where you **live** — the commute is what kills consistency in Bali traffic. Seseh/Canggu: Omni, Nirvana, or Reload. Bukit: Bambu. For pure recovery, **The Istana** and **Atmos** in Uluwatu are world-class (float tanks, cold plunge, sauna), and Omni and Nirvana cover it up north.

Also worth knowing: **Body Factory** (Berawa) for a polished all-rounder with pool and ice baths, and **Obsidian** (Pererenan), one of the largest in Asia.

PART IV — LIVE IT

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**Where to meet
people.**

The secret about Bali: it's one of the easiest places on earth to build a community fast, because everyone here is also new and open. You just have to put yourself in the rooms.

Co-working — the social on-ramp

- **Dojo Bali** (Echo Beach, Canggu) — 24/7, legendary for networking.
- **Outpost** — Canggu plus two in Ubud (Penestanan, Nyuh Kuning); coworking + coliving + weekly events.
- **BWork** and **Tropical Nomad** (Canggu); **Lacuna** for the Uluwatu crowd.

Founders & investors

- **Bali Investment Club** — impact-investing community and events.
- **United Founders / Bali Capital Connect** — private founder network with serious investor intros.
- **Startup Grind Bali** and founder dinners — Canggu/Berawa is the hub.

Padel — the great connector

Padel is booming and it's the fastest way to meet people through play. **Bali Padel Academy**, **Canggu Padel @ Finns**, and **Bali Social Club** in the Canggu area; **Island Sports Club** in Uluwatu (courts, café, also fitness and golf). Show up to a social-match night and you'll have ten new numbers by the end.

MY TAKE

Pick three recurring anchors — a gym, a co-working spot, and one sport or class — and just keep showing up. Bali rewards consistency; the same faces become your people within weeks. The lineup at your local surf break and your gym's group classes do more than any "networking event."

PART IV — LIVE IT

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**The best of the
island.**

This is the easy part. Here's the shortlist I'd give anyone who wants to actually **use** Bali, not just live near it.

Surf

World-class breaks on the Bukit — **Uluwatu**, **Padang Padang**, **Bingin** (advanced, best in the dry season). **Keramas** on the east (and night surfing), **Medewi**'s long left. Beginners: start at **Batu Bolong / Old Man's** in Canggu or mellow Sanur.

Ocean & diving

Nusa Penida for manta rays year-round (and seasonal mola mola), a 45-min boat from Sanur. **Amed** and **Tulamben** in the east — the **USAT Liberty wreck** is a magical shore dive, great for free-divers and beginners.

Land & adventure

- **Mount Batur** sunrise hike — an active volcano, eggs cooked in volcanic steam at the top.
- **The Nusa islands** — Penida's Kelingking "T-Rex" cliff, chiller Lembongan.
- **Waterfalls** — Sekumpul (the north's finest), Tukad Cepung's light-beam cave, Aling-Aling's jumps.
- **Sidemen** & the **Tegallalang** rice terraces for the green, quiet Bali.

Temples & culture

Tanah Lot and **Uluwatu Temple** (the nightly Kecak fire dance is a must), the **Lempuyang** "Gates of Heaven," and **Besakih**, the Mother Temple. Go early, dress respectfully.

Wellness

The Istana and **Atmos** (Uluwatu) for serious biohacking — float tanks, cold plunge, sound saunas. **Pyramids of Chi** (Ubud) for sound healing and breathwork, **The Yoga Barn** for yoga and gong baths. Ice baths are everywhere, especially in Canggu.

MY ULTIMATE HIT-LIST

If you only do a handful of things, do these:

- **Rafting** through the Ubud jungle
- **Snorkelling with manta rays** at Nusa Penida
- **Dirt biking** the volcano
- **Surfing** Uluwatu
- **Mount Batur** for sunrise
- **Night-diving the USAT Liberty wreck** at Amed — eerie and unforgettable
- One big night at **Savaya** for the view

PART IV — LIVE IT

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My favorite spots.

The personal list — the places I actually send friends to when they land. Sorted by the three corners of the island I love most.

Canggu & Seseh — eat here

My regulars: **Open House** in Seseh, **Clove**, **Mostly**, and **Numero Quattro**. That four-spot rotation covers everything from a slow morning to a proper dinner without ever leaving the neighbourhood.

Uluwatu — eat & swim

Kala and **Ulu Fish Market** for dinner. And my favourite daytime move on the whole island: **Delpi Warung** down at the beach — go for the cliff pool during the day, swim, eat, and watch the surfers. It's the kind of afternoon you moved here for.

Ubud — the magic

Gdas and **Donna** are my go-tos, and **Merlin's** is genuinely a magical experience — save that one for a night you want to remember.

Recovery

In Uluwatu, **The Istana** and **Atmos** are both incredible for recovery and biohacking. In Seseh, **Omni** or **Nirvana** double as gym and recovery in one.

Going out

If you go out for one big night, make it **Savaya** — the view is just unreal. Sunset into the night there is hard to beat anywhere in the world.

IF YOU DO ONE THING

A slow day at **Delpi** — cliff pool, the beach below, a long lunch and a surf. It's the simplest, most "this is why I'm here" day Bali offers.

PART IV — LIVE IT

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Your first 30 days.

Pull it together into a sequence. Do these roughly in order and the chaos becomes a checklist.

Week 1 — land & connect

- ☐ Enter on your eVoA or B211A; keep every document and the customs QR
- ☐ Register your phone's **IMEI** at the airport (or commit to a roaming eSIM)
- ☐ Buy a **Telkomsel** SIM and set up WhatsApp
- ☐ Download **Gojek** and **Grab**; book short-term accommodation
- ☐ Rent a scooter from a reputable place (helmets included)

Weeks 2–3 — find your feet

- ☐ Scooter through 2–3 areas (Uluwatu, Seseh, South Ubud) at different times of day
- ☐ Sort **insurance** with explicit scooter + medevac cover
- ☐ Buy your **IDP** if you didn't bring one; always carry it
- ☐ Visit a co-working space and one gym; start your three anchors

Week 4 — commit

- ☐ Talk to two reputable **visa agents**; choose your KITAS path

- ☐ Once on a KITAS: get your **SKTT**, open a **BCA** account, get your **NPWP**
- ☐ Sign a longer **lease** only now — on the street you're sure of
- ☐ If buying property or running a business, start the **PT PMA** with a notary

MY TAKE

Resist the urge to lock everything in during week one. The people who love Bali long-term are the ones who tested it slow, found their street and their people, and only **then** committed money and paperwork. Move deliberately. You're not on holiday — you're choosing an input that will shape years of your life.

TEAR THIS OUT

**The numbers that
matter.**

A one-page reference. Verify before relying on any figure — Indonesia moves fast.

ITEM	FIGURE
VoA (eVoA)	Rp 500k · 30 days, +30 once
B211A / C1	~Rp 1.9M · 60 days, up to 180
Remote KITAS (E33G)	\$60k income · ~\$850 · 1 yr
Investor KITAS (E28A)	via PT PMA · ~\$1,200 · 2 yr
Overstay fine	Rp 1,000,000 / day
SKTT	Free · within 14 days of KITAS
PT PMA paid-up capital	Rp 2.5B (~\$155k)
Tax residency	> 183 days/year
SIM data	Rp 100–200k / month
IMEI duty-free	\$500 · then 40% over
Scooter rent	Rp 700k–1.5M / month
New Scoopy	~Rp 20.5–23.7M
Local licence (A+C)	Rp 400,000
BPJS health	~Rp 150k / month
Comfortable cost of living	~\$1,800–2,500 / month

Emergency: 112 (general) · BIMC Hospital Kuta +62 361 761263
· always have evacuation cover.

ONE LAST THING

That's all of it. Now go live here.

That really is everything you need to know. None of it is hard once you can see it whole — a handful of things, done once, and then you're free to enjoy the best place on earth. Get the simple stuff sorted, then go live the part you came for.

The Game of Life — if you want the deeper book on **why** to design your life this way, start there.

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